

Session 28: Jacob and Esau Part Ways

Key Takeaways

- The brothers, Yaaqov and Esau, cannot dwell together in unity because they have too much wealth, most of it obtained through deception.
- The genealogies in Genesis show us that the narrative is laser-focused on tracing the lineage of the hoped-for messianic king who will crush the snake.
- The Yaaqov story explores the nuance and complexity of human motives in a way that is truly unique in the Hebrew Bible.

Brothers Who Cannot Dwell Together in Unity

36:1 And these are the generations of Esau (this is Edom).

² **Esau took his wives** from the daughters of **Canaan**:

Adah, daughter of Elon the Hittite,

and **Oholibamah**, daughter of of Anah, daughter of Zib'on the Hivite,

³ and **Basemath**, daughter of Yishmael, sister of Nebaiyoth.

⁴ And **Adah** birthed for Esau Eliphaz,

and **Basemath** birthed Re'u'el,

⁵ and **Oholibamah** birthed Ye'ush and Ya'lam and Qorakh.

These are the sons of Esau that were born for him in the land of Canaan.

⁶ **And Esau took his wives** ¹

and his sons²

and his daughters³

and all the people of his house,⁴

and his herds⁵

and his beasts⁶

and all his **possessions** ⁷ that he accumulated in the land of **Canaan**,

and he went to **the land** opposite the face of Yaaqov his brother,

⁷ because their **possessions** were too many for them to dwell together as one,

and **the land** of their migrations was not able to carry them,

because of their **possessions**.

⁸ **And Esau dwelt in the mountains of Seir**.

Esau, he is Edom.

A **36:9-19** These are the generations of Esau, father of Edom, in Mount Seir

36:9 "Esau, father of Edom"

36:19 "Esau, he is Edom"

B **36:20-30** These are the sons of Seir the Horite, dwellers of the land

B' **36:31-39** These are the kings who ruled in the land Edom

A' **36:40-43** These are the names of the chiefs of Esau

36:43 "He is Esau, father of Edom"

37:1 And Yaaqov dwelt

in the land of the migrations of his father,

in the land of Canaan.

Genesis 36:1-37:1. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).

At the conclusion of the Yaaqov story, we find a narrative that returns us to the drama of Yaaqov and Esau that began this movement of the Genesis scroll. Yaaqov and Esau, who were rivals from birth, are now wealthy and have many people and possessions in their households. In fact, they have too many, and so they cannot dwell together.

Notice the focus on Esau's seven-fold household (the list has seven items). This is meant to recall Abraham and Lot's inability to dwell in the same land because of their many possessions.

Abraham and Lot	Yaaqov and Esau
Gen. 12:10-20 Abraham accumulated wealth through his deception of Pharaoh	Gen. 27, 30 Yaaqov accumulates wealth through his deception of his father and his uncle
Gen. 13:2 "And Abram was very heavy with herds and with silver and with gold."	Gen. 36:6 "And [Esau] ... went to the land opposite the face of Yaaqov his brother."
Gen. 13:5-6 "Now, also belonging to Lot, who went with Abram, were flocks and cattle and tents. And the land could not carry them for dwelling together, for their possessions were so many, and they were not able to dwell together."	Gen. 36:7 "Because their possessions were too many for them to dwell together as one, and the land of their migrations was not able to carry them, because of their possessions."
Disunity Among Brothers. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).	

Abraham and Lot	Yaaqov and Esau
Gen. 13:12 “Abram dwelt in the land of Canaan, and Lot dwelt in the cities of the valley, and he set up his tent by Sodom.”	Gen. 36:8 “And Esau dwelt in the mountains of Seir. Esau, he is Edom.” Gen. 37:1 “And Yaaqov dwelt in the land of the migrations of his father, in the land of Canaan.”
Lot ends up sleeping with his daughters and becoming the father of the Moabites and Ammonites, who live east of the Jordan and are hostile to Israel.	Esau ends up marrying an Ishmaelite wife and becoming the father of the Edomites, who live east of the Jordan and are hostile to Israel.
<i>Disunity Among Brothers. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).</i>	

In Genesis 12-13, Abraham’s ill-gotten gain causes a rupture in the family, so he cannot dwell with his brother in peace. That conflict ended peacefully in the short term, but eventually Lot became the father of the Moabites and Ammonites. These tribes go on to become long-term rivals who are hostile to Israel.

Similarly, in Genesis 36, Yaaqov’s ill-gotten blessing and wealth also cause a rupture, and he cannot live with Esau in peace. So the brothers separate, becoming the fathers of tribes who will be hostile to each other for centuries to come.

⁹ And these are the generations of Esau, the father of Edom in the mountains of Seir.

¹⁰ **These are the names of the sons of Esau :**
Eliphaz, son of Adah, wife of Esau;
Re’u’el, son of Basemat, wife of Esau.

¹¹ And **the sons of Eliphaz** were:
Teman, Omar, Zepho and Ga’tam and Qenaz.

¹² **And Timna’ was the concubine of Eliphaz, son of Esau, and she birthed Amaleq for Eliphaz.**
These are the **sons of Adah, wife of Esau.**

¹³ And these are **the sons of Re’u’el:**
Nakhat and Zerakh, Shammah and Mizzah.
These were **the sons of Basemat, wife of Esau.**

¹⁴ And these were **the sons of Oholibamah,** daughter of Anah, daughter of Zib’on, **wife of Esau,** and she birthed for Esau **Ya’ush and Ya’lam and Qorakh.**

15 **These are the chiefs of the sons of Esau :**

the sons of Eliphaz, firstborn of Esau:

chief Teman, chief Omar, chief Zepho, chief Qenaz,

16 **chief Qorakh, chief Ga'tam, chief Amaleq.**

These are the chiefs of Eliphaz in the land of Edom.

These are the **sons of Adah.**

17 And these are the chiefs of **the sons of Re'u'el**, son of Esau:

chief Nekath, chief Zerakh, chief Shaman, chief Mizzah.

These are the chiefs of Re'u'el in the land of Edom,

these are **the sons of Basemat, wife of Esau.**

18 And these are **the sons of Oholibamah, wife of Esau:**

chief Ya'ush, chief Ya'lam, chief Qorakh.

These are the chiefs of Oholibamah, daughter of Anah, wife of Esau.

19 **These are the sons of Esau ,
and these are their chiefs .**

He is Edom.

Genesis 36:9-19. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).

20 **These are the sons of Seir the Horite, the dwellers of the land :**

Lotan ¹ and **Shobal** ² and **Zib'on** ³ and **Anah** ,⁴

21 and **Dishon** ⁵ and **Etser** ⁶ and **Dishan** .⁷

These are the chiefs of the Horite, sons of Seir in the land of Edom .

22 And the sons of **Lotan** were Horite and Hemam.

And the sister of Lotan was Timna'.

23 And these are the sons of **Shobal** :

Alwan and Mankhat and Ebal, Shepho and Onam.

24 And these are the sons of **Zib'on** :

Ayah and **Anah**.

(This is the **Anah** who found the hot water springs in the wilderness,
when he was shepherding the donkeys of **Zib'on** his father.)

25 And these are the sons of **Anah**:

Dishon and Oholibamah the daughter of **Anah**.

26 And these are the sons of **Dishon** :

Khemdan and Eshban and Yitran and Keran.

27 These are the sons of **Etser** :

Bilhan and Ze'on and Aqan.

28 These are the sons of **Dishan** :

29 **These are the chiefs of the Horite :**

chief **Lotan** ,¹ chief **Shobal** ,² chief **Zib'on** ,³ chief **Anah** ,⁴

30 chief **Dishon** ,⁵ chief **Etser** ,⁶ chief **Dishan** .⁷

These are the chiefs of the Horite by their chiefs in the land of Seir .

Genesis 36:20-30. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).

31 And these are **the kings who reigned as kings**

in the land of Edom ,

before **a king reigned as king**

for the sons of Yisrael .

32 And Bela' son of Be'or **reigned as king** ,

and the name of his city was Dinhabah .

33 And Bela' died,

and Yobab son of Zerakh **reigned as king** in his place **from Botzrah .**

34 And Yobab died,

and Khusham **reigned** as king in his place **from the land of the Temanite .**

35 And Khusham died,

and Hadad son of Bedad **reigned as king** in his place,

the one who who struck Midyan in the field of Moab,

and the name of his city was Avith .

36 And Hadad died,

and Samlah from Masreqah **reigned as king** in his place.

37 And Samlah died,

and Sha'ul from Rekhoboth-Hanahar **reigned as king** in his place.

38 And Sha'ul died,

and Ba'al Khanan son of Akhbor **reigned as king** in his place.

39 And Ba'al Khanan son of Akhbor died,

and Hadar **reigned as king** in his place,

and the name of his city was Pa'u ,

and the name of his wife was Mehetab'el,

daughter of Matred,

daughter of Mey-Zahab

Genesis 36:31-39. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).

40 **And these are the names of the chiefs of Esau,**

by their families, by their places, by their names:

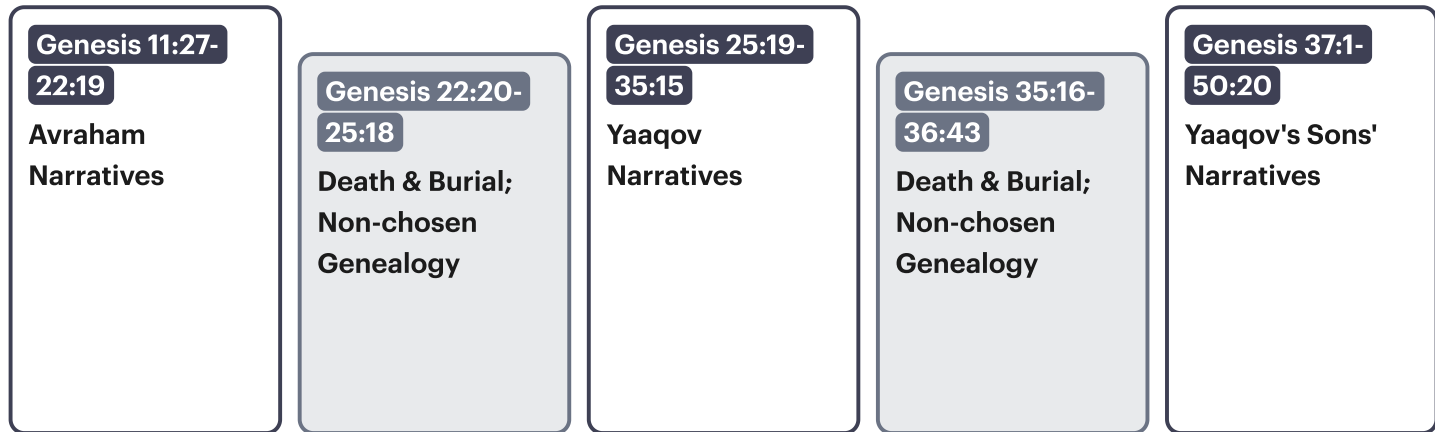
chief Timna', chief 'Alwah, chief Yetet
41 chief Oholibamah, chief Elah, chief Pinon,
42 chief Qenaz, chief Teman, chief Mibtzar,
43 chief Magdi'el, chief 'Iram.

These are the chiefs of Edom,

by their dwellings, in the land of their possession.

This is **Esau**, the father of **Edom**.

Genesis 36:40-43. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).



Genesis 11:27-50:20. Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

This pattern highlights an important compositional design that occurs throughout the entire Genesis scroll. The main narrative traces the lineage of the promised seed to a set of siblings. Then, after the story of their separation, the non-chosen line is ushered off the stage with a genealogy that extends far past the narrative time perspective. After this, the narrative backtracks and focuses on the chosen line, picking up their story.

 Diagram showing where genealogies in Genesis branch between chosen and non-chosen lines.
Genealogies in Genesis. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

Reflection Question

How do the genealogies in Genesis shape the narrative, and what does this shape indicate about the narrative's focus?